My Mother Learns English

By Patricia Smith

An anxious immigrant at 64, my mother is learning
English.
Pulling Sears Best cinnamon stockings to a roll beneath
her knees,
sitting that Baptist ski slope of a hat on her head,
she rides the rattling El train to a steel spire in
downtown Chicago,
pulls back her gulp as the glass elevator hurtles upward
and comes to sit at a gleaming oak table
across from a pinstriped benevolent white angel
who has dedicated two hours a week
to straightening the black, twisted tongues of the
afflicted.
It is this woman's job to scrape the moist infection
of Aliceville, Alabama from my mother's throat.

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INTRODUCTION

"Y'all" isn't welcome . . . And forget about "fixin'," as in getting ready to do something, people with strong Southern accents are often perceived as "slow and dimwitted." But it's "sort of a shame" that people should feel the need to soften or even lose their accents. Patricia Smith laments the loss of personal culture as her very Southern mother becomes determined to fit into the Northern culture . . . language and all in "My Mother Learns English."

"I want to talk right before I die," my mother says,
"Want to stop saying 'ain't' and 'I done been' like I just
got off the boat."
My mother has never been on a boat.
But 50 years ago, a million of her, clutching strapped
cloth suitcases
and peppery fried chicken in waxed bags,
stepped off the buses at the Greyhound depot in
Chicago,
eagerly brushing the stubborn red dust from their
shoes.
"We North now," they all said, still in their southern
tongues,

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as if those three words were vessels big enough to hold
it all, all those dreams with bulging seams, dreams
that spilled over the borders of sleeping, dreams that
hurt the eyes with their feverish glow, dreams that
got drunk on sweet water and whispered promises.
My mother's northern dreams were simple, but huge—
she thought it a modern miracle to live in a box
stacked upon other boxes, a tenement apartment where
every surface smelled of Lysol and effort, and plum
roaches, cross-eyed with spray, dragged themselves
across
freshly washed dishes, dropped dizzily from the ceiling
into our food, our beds. Mama's huge dream required
starch stiff pinafores, orlon sweaters with stitched
roses
and A-line skirts in the color of winter. There had to be

a tavern on the corner with a jukebox where men begged
forgiveness in gravel voices and a comfortable stool by
the door, where mama could sit and look like a Christian

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who was just leaving. She needed a job that didn't
involve
soil or branches, in a factory where she could work in a
straight line with other women, *repedida, repedida,*
repedida,
no talking allowed, their heads drooping with dreams.
Within walking distance of wherever she lived, there had
to be a Baptist Church where she could pull on the white
gloves of service and wail to the rafters when she felt
the
hot hand of the Holy Ghost pressing insistent at the
small
of her back. Yes, Jesus had to be there—He had
blessed
her journey so far, quickened her step, stroked her free
of the Delta. She was His child, building herself anew
here where the burning of her hair was a ritual and she'd
given up wearing pants because the Lord said she should.
Her dreams for the most part realized, my mother now
busies
herself preparing for burial, stashing away a dollar here,

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a dollar there, to pay for her own coffin, not wanting to bother
me, as she says, *with that nonsense*. She instructs me not to
spend lots of money putting her under, and once again sternly
relates the story of the dutiful daughter who neglected details,
so her dead mother's body was sent to church #1 while
everyone waited to mourn in church #2. *If that happened,*
chile, I'd be so embarrassed. No mother, I think, you would
be so dead, but I don't dare actually bring this to voice
because Annie Pearl Smith is not a fan of humor.
She is retired now after 40 years working in a candy factory,
making malted milk balls, hot dog gum and candy corn.
She'd been gone from the place for a year before she could

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scrub the stark sugar smell out of her skin. When my father
was murdered, almost 25 years ago, mama and I gazed at
each other across a huge yawning chasm, we had no idea
one about the other. I had spent so many hopeful years
dousing my father in my dreams and he had listened

while my mother cursed a comb through my nappy hair,
nagged me to sit up straight, checked my grades, led me
to church, and grabbed the switch when I sassed.
She didn't talk unless talking was necessary.
Now she says it hurt her that I gave him everything.
So, of course, now I want to get to know her.
I know she doesn't believe men ever landed on the moon,
that the whole thing was staged in some Arizona desert
because *American folks are stupid that way and always will be*.
I know she had a hysterectomy and never told me.
I know that her motto was *Always be respectful of white folks*.
I know she only *thinks* she is dying soon, because it is

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fashionable when you are old and black and Christian
to think so. I know that I never realized
that the way she spoke
was ever a problem
for anyone
especially her
especially me
My mother's voice:
--It's like cornbread, buttery and full of places for heat to hide.
--When she is angry, it curls into a fist and punches straight out.
--When she is scared, it gathers strength and turns practical, matter-of-fact, like when she is calling her daughter to say *they found your father this morning, someone shot him and he is very dead.*
--She can't sing, not a lick, not at all. When she tries, her voice cracks and collapses and loses all acquaintance with a key, and every Sunday morning it's my mother's voice that's the loudest, unleashed and creaking toward glory.

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--When my mama talks, the sound of it is flat and broad and wild with unexpected flowers, like fields in Alabama.

--She has never been grammatically correct. Her rap is peppered with *ain't gots* and *don't have nones* and *I done beens* and *she be's* and *he be's* the way mine is when I'm sweet color among coloreds and don't have to worry about being graded. I see no shame in this. You can't do wrong in the process of unwrapping a dream.

Turns out now one of my mother's leftover dreams
Is to wash history from her throat, to talk like a woman
got some sense and future, to talk English instead
of talking
wrong
Yes, I am a poet, privy to the shoes of others,

But I want my mother to be my teacher

To talk to me, one colored girl to another
To warm me up with double negatives

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To take me down south

And leave me there

But I pick up the phone these days

and she is on the other end,

precisely using her new mouth.

She forgets sometimes, of course, but she

is proud of what she remembers, and it hurts

me to hear her effort, the sum of all her dreams

this one dream, whizzing us back to that moment

50 years ago, on the Greyhound bus headed for

the Windy City from Alabama—

my southern mother in one seat, dead since Memphis,

and my northern mother in the seat next to herself,

lost in that mean, unreachable dream.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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